Timeline of Writing Systems' Graphical Evolution

Chart by u/DPenner1
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2000 BC · 1800 BC · 1600 BC · 1400 BC · 1200 BC · 1000 BC · 800 BC · 600 BC · 400 BC · 200 BC · 1 AD · 200 AD · 400 AD · 600 AD · 800 AD · 1000 AD · 1200 AD · 1400 AD · 1600 AD · 1800 AD · 1850 AD · 1900 AD · 1950 AD · 2000 AD

Modern Era (timescale change)

Legend

- **Hellenic**: Scripts derived from Greek
- **Sinitic**: Scripts derived from Oracle Bone
- **Northern Brahmi**: Scripts derived from Brahmi in North India
- **Semitic**: Scripts derived from Proto-Sinaitic
- **Southern Brahmi**: Scripts derived from Brahmi in South India
- **Other**: Independently derived scripts (graphically)

Bold: Over 10 million users
Bold underline: Over 100 million users
Italics: Not in Unicode

Script extinction then revival:

▼▲◄► **Writing direction**
文 **Logograph**: Words are distinct characters
か **Syllabary**: Syllables are distinct characters
ふ 𐤀 Ω **Alphabets**: Consonants are distinct characters
Ω **True alphabet**: Vowels are on par with consonants
𑀅 **Abugida**: Vowels are secondary, usually diacritics
ふ **Abjad**: Vowels are optional or non-existant

Central & East Asia

文 Tangut ▼
か Nushu ▼
文か Khitan Small ▼◄
文 Simplified Chinese ►►
文 *Oracle Bone* ▼ · 文 *Large Seal* ▼ · 文 *Small Seal* ▼ · 文 Clerical ▼ · 文 **Regular / Traditional Chinese (Hanzi / Kanji / Hanja / Chu Han)** ▼►►
か *Man'yogana* ▼
Ωか **Bopomofo** ►◄
か **Katakana** ▼►
か **Hiragana** ▼►
Reform: obsoleted kana named Hentaigana
文 *Classical Yi* ▼
か Modern Yi ►

South Asia

ふ Khwarezmian ◄
from Aramaic (West Asia)
ふ Old Sogdian ◄ · ふ Sogdian ◄►
from Lik-Tai (Southeast Asia)
𑀲 Tai Le ►
Ωふ Old Uyghur ▼◄►
from Tai Tham (Southeast Asia)
𑀲 New Tai Lue ►
Ω Mongolian ▼
Ω Old Turkic ◄
𑀲 Marchen ►
Ωか **Hangul** ►▼
𑀲 Zanabazar square ►
𑀲 Soyombo ►
from Canadian Aboriginal
𑀲 Pollard Miao ►
Ωか 'Phags-pa ▼
Ω𑀲 Fraser / Lisu ►
𑀲 Tibetan ►
from Latin (Europe)
𑀲 Khema ►
𑀲 Lepcha ►
𑀲 Limbu ►
𑀲 Kirat Rai ►
𑀲 Meitei ►
𑀲 Bhaiksuki ►
Ω𑀲 Sunuwar ►
𑀲 *Ranjana* ►
𑀲 *Newari* ►
𑀲 Prachalit / Newa ►
𑀲 Tirhuta ►
𑀲 *Gaudi* ►
𑀲 **Odia** ►
𑀲 **Bengali-Assamese** ►
𑀲 *Gupta* ►
𑀲 Siddham ►
𑀲 Sylheti Nagri ►
𑀲 Kaithi ►
Ω *Chisoi* ►
𑀲 Modi ►
Ω Toto ►
𑀲 Gunjala Gondi ►
𑀲 **Gujarati** ►
𑀲 Northern Nagari ►
𑀲 **Devanagari** ►
𑀲 *Nagari* ►
𑀲 Masaram Gondi ►
𑀲 Nandinagari ►
𑀲 Dogri ►
Ω Warang Citi ►
𑀲 *Devasesa* ►
𑀲 Takri ►
Ω Ol Onal ►
𑀲 Sharada ►
𑀲 Khojki ►
Ω Mru ►
𑀲 Multani ►
Ω Wancho ►
𑀲 *Landa* ►
𑀲 Khudabadi ►
𑀲 **Gurmukhi** ►
𑀲ふ Mahajani ►
Ω Sorang Sompeng ►
𑀲 Brahmi ►
𑀲 *Kadamba* ►
𑀲 *Telugu-Kannada* ►
𑀲 **Kannada** ►
𑀲 **Telugu** ►
Ω Mundari Bani ►
𑀲 **Tamil** ►
𑀲 **Sinhala** ►
𑀲 **Malayalam** ►
𑀲 *Tigalari-Malayalam* ►
𑀲 Tigalari ►
𑀲 *Pallava* ►
𑀲 Grantha ►
𑀲 Saurashtra ►
𑀲 Dhives Akuru ►
Ω Tolong Siki ►
Ω Avestan ◄
𑀲 Thaana ◄
𑀲 Chakma ►
Ω Ol Chiki ►
𑀲 Ahom ►
Ω Tangsa ►
Ω Pau Cin Hau ►
Ω Hanifi Rohingya ◄
𑀲 *Lik-Tai* ►
𑀲 *Old Mon* ►
𑀲 **Mon-Burmese** ►
Ω Kayah Li ►
𑀲 Tai Tham ►
𑀲 Lai Tay / Tai Yo ▼
𑀲 **Khmer** ►
𑀲 Tai Viet ►
𑀲 *Sukhothai* ►
𑀲 **Thai** ►
𑀲 *Fakkham* ►
𑀲 Lao ►
𑀲 Pahawh Hmong ►
𑀲 Cham ►
𑀲 Balinese ►
𑀲 Ulu ►
𑀲 Rejang ►
𑀲 Sundanese ►
𑀲 *Old Sundanese* ►
𑀲 Javanese ►
𑀲 Kawi ►
𑀲 Makasar ►
𑀲 Lontara / Bugis ►
𑀲 Batak ►
𑀲 Baybayin ►
𑀲 Hanuno'o ►
𑀲 Tagbanwa ►
𑀲 Buhid ►

~2800 BC 文か *Indus* ◄►

Southeast Asia

West Asia
(excl. Anatolia & Caucasus)

ふ Elymaic ◄
ふ *Book Pahlavi* ◄
ふ Inscriptional Pahlavi ◄
Ω Yezidi ◄
ふ Psalter Pahlavi ◄
ふ Hatran ◄
ふ Nabataean ◄
ふ **Arabic** ◄
かΩ Old Persian Cuneiform ►
ふ Hebrew ◄
~2800 BC 文か Sumero-Akkadian Cuneiform ►
ふ Manichaean ◄
ふ Palmyrene ◄
ふ Syriac ◄
ふ Ugaritic ►
ふ Aramaic ◄
ふ Phoenician ◄
Ω Mandaic ◄
ふ Inscriptional Parthian ◄
ふ *Paleo-Hebrew* ◄
ふ Samaritan ◄
ふ Ancient North Arabian ◄
ふ Ancient South Arabian ◄►

Africa

ふ *Proto-Sinaitic* ◄►▼
ふ *Old Ge'ez* ◄
𑀲 **Ge'ez** ►
ふ *Libyco-Berber* ▲◄
Ω Bassa Vah ►
ふ Tifinagh ▲◄
Ω Neo-Tifinagh ►
Ω Medefaidrin ►
Ω Garay ◄
Ω Osmanya ►
Ω Adlam ◄
~3250 BC 文ふ Egyptian Hieroglyphs ◄►▼
ふかΩ Meroitic Hieroglyphics ◄►
か Bamum ►
Ω N'Ko ◄
文ふ Hieratic ◄
文ふ Abnormal Hieratic ◄
Ω Zaghawa / Beria ►
ふかΩ Meroitic Cursive ◄
か Mende Kikakui ◄
文ふ *Demotic* ◄
か Vai ►
Ω Coptic ►
Ω Sidetic ◄
文 Anatolian Hieroglyphs ►
from Old Turkic (Mongolia)
Ω Old Hungarian ◄
Ω *Night Writing* ►◄
Ω Braille ►

Europe, Anatolia & Caucasus

文か Linear A ►
か Linear B ►
か Cypro-Minoan ►
か Cypriot ◄
Ω Caucasian Albanian ►
Ω Asomtavruli ►
Ω Nushkuri ►
Ω Mkhedruli ►
Ω Armenian ►
Ω **Greek** ►
Greek miniscule (lowercase letter forms)
Ω Carian ►◄
Ω Gothic ►
Ω Old Permic ►
Ω Vithkuqi ►
Ω Shavian ►
Ω Lydian ◄
Ω **Cyrillic** ►
Ω Lycian ►
Ω Glagolitic ►
Ω SignWriting ►▼
Ω **Latin** ► ABCdefg
Carolingian miniscule (lowercase letter forms)
Ω Old Italic ►◄
Ω Todhri ►
Ω Duployan Shorthand ►
Ω Elder Futhark ►◄
Ω Younger Futhark ►◄
Ω Medieval Runes ►
Ω Dalecarlian Runes ►
Ω Ogham ▲►
Ω Elbasan ►
𑀲 *Pitman Shorthand* ►

Americas

文か *Maya* ◄►▼
Ω Osage ►
from Hebrew (Israel)
from Lao
Ω Nyiakeng Puachue Hmong ►
Ω Deseret ►
from Devanagari (India)
𑀲 Canadian Aboriginal ►
か Cherokee ►